

Video transcript

Digital threats

Think about how many hours a day you spend using digital technologies like computers, tablets, and smartphones, whether for school, work, or fun. Now, think about all the threats that you might face while processing and sharing digital information. Drawing a blank? When you use these technologies, you open yourself to a plethora of attacks.

Threats and attacks are more sophisticated than ever, and attackers are getting smarter. Attackers look for any weakness that they can exploit. To protect yourself from attacks, you need to know the threats and the vulnerabilities that they target.

One of the top digital threats is viruses. A virus is any program on a computer that can infect a system without a user's permission. They're usually placed there by a malicious entity trying to gain control or cause damage. Ever heard of someone's data getting erased suddenly from their computer? Ever wonder how that happened? One answer might be a virus.

Another common digital threat is adware. Adware is unwanted software designed to throw advertisements up on your screen, usually in your web browser. When you click them, you expose yourself to a malicious attack. There are also physical threats to your digital life. Take a keylogger, which does exactly what it sounds like. A keylogger records what you type on your device. Imagine if an attacker placed a keylogger on your doctor's computer. With that tool in place, the attacker can access data about the doctor. They can also access passwords, patient data, medical data, financial data, and more.

Thinking about all these looming threats gets overwhelming. What are the solutions? You can put security controls into place to try to prevent attacks from succeeding. Some controls are software-based, such as antivirus programs to detect and prevent viruses, or ad blockers to prevent unwanted and potentially malicious advertisements. Some controls reside in industry standards like CIS Controls and NIST.

When you use the internet, you become exposed to digital threats. Learning more about these threats, and some security controls you can implement, will help you keep your digital life as secure as possible.